Approaching Megasthenes

Little is known about the early life of Megasthenes. He was probably born around 350 BCE and likely spent part of his life in Arachosia, near modern Helmand in south Afghanistan, serving a governor of Alexander. He spent at least a few months, possibly a few years, in Pataliputra (modern Patna), the Mauryan capital. He may have died around 290 BCE.

Megasthenes wrote an account of his Indian sojourn, *Indica*. Sadly, the original text is lost; only parts of it survive as paraphrased text by Graeco-Roman authors, including Diodorus Siculus, Strabo, Pliny the Elder and Arrian. (E.A. Schwanbeck compiled all such fragments in 1846 to make the text that now passes as *Indica*, and J.W. McCrindle translated it into English in 1877.[14]) But these authors paraphrase unreliably, add their own masala or include ideas from other sources, and often contradict each other. This makes it hard to draw accurate inferences about the original.

One inference that seems secure is that Megasthenes was an immensely curious man. He also comes across as an animal lover, especially drawn to elephants in India. He recognizes their intelligence and accurately records their lifecycle, mating posture and several other behaviours. He describes how they're captured and domesticated for war, and how Indians cure the animals' wounds. He also records a charming custom. When an elephant is angry and won't be pacified by mere food, its handlers 'sing to it their native melodies, and soothe it with the music of an instrument in common use which has four strings and is called a *skindapsos*. The creature now pricks up its ears, yields to the soothing strain, and its anger subsides'. This ancient custom will delight those who provide music therapy to elephants in sanctuaries today.

However, Megasthenes, like Herodotus, seems to have written down both what he saw and what he heard. For the places he did not visit, he displays poor judgement in recording absurd hearsay as truth. He mentions people with the ears of a dog and only one eye in the middle of the forehead; people with no mouths and mere orifices for nostrils, who live on the odours of roots and flowers; a pygmy tribe less than 27 inches tall; people who live a thousand years; people with ears reaching down to their feet; people with feet turned backwards; and so on.